

DOES FILE SHARING DURING DEBATES ENABLE EFFECTIVE JUDGING?

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Abstract: The rapid movement toward paperless debate enables pre-speech sharing with opponents, but norms about the scope of sharing beyond those actively debating have been slower to evolve. This paper will explore the implications of widening the circle, both during and after the round, with wider audiences including: judges, official scouts, unofficial scouts, those in the policy community not present, and those beyond the community. It will also explore possible technologies for broader sharing, such as Dropbox, email, flash drives, PADS, and the debate citation wiki. It will specifically advocate including at least the judge in real time sharing, and creation of a norm allowing the widest possible sharing, and utilizing an opt-out system instead of an opt-in system. The costs and benefits of extending these norms to debaters remaining tied to paper will also be explored.

College policy debate (NDT/CEDA format) has moved dramatically in the direction of computerized speaking documents. The introduction of the *Verbatim* template for paperless debating in 2008 preceded rapid movement toward paperless debating. In prior years, standard practice was to make evidence available to the opponent in real time (during the speech) and available to the judge, upon request, at the end of the debate. This norm translated into an expectation that paperless speeches be available to the opponent immediately before the speech, but the ease of sharing resulted in some judges (including the author) requesting the same access. Although paperless debating is still far from uniform in adoption, debaters nearly always have immediate access to the speech documents, but judges less so. The utility of judges receiving immediate access to speech

documents is an unsettled issue and there are strong opinions on both sides of the question. Most opponents of judge access during rounds worry that the quality of listening will decrease, due to reductions in incentive, focus, or speaker clarity. Thus, this paper will explore the controversy surrounding judges' advance acquisition of speech documents as it relates to the listening process. Although the conclusion favors including judges in pre-speech file sharing, there are important drawbacks for individual judges to consider when experimenting with the practice.

Judging as Listening

Listening skills may be the most portable of all skills developed in debate training. Listening has received limited attention from textbooks and other debate resources relative to critical thinking, speaking, and research, but it received a full unit of focus in one text (California High School Speech Association's Curriculum Committee, 2004), and was frequently cited by students in a Debate Across the Curriculum experiment in health education (Hall, 2011). Listening skill development is encouraged to enhance debate performance in several textbooks (Freeley & Steinberg, 2013; Hensley & Carlin, 2004; Patterson & Zarefsky, 1983).

Humans spend over 25% of their lives listening (Louhils-Salminen, 1999; Walther, 1992). Effective listening has been tied to self-knowledge & well-being (Abbott, 2007; Collingwood, 2001; Conchie, 2007), educational achievement (Wolff & Marsnik, 1992), relationship maintenance (Purdy, 1991), and leadership effectiveness (Steil & Bommelje, 2004). In a management context, 80% of executives consider listening the most vital skill (Salopek, 1999), while 60% of errors are attributed to poor listening (Cooper, 1997). In nearly any career, listening is critical (Boyle, 1999; Feiertag, 2002;

Johnson & Bechler, 1998; Lobdell, Sonoda & Arnold, 1993; Sypher, Bostrom, & Seibert, 1989), and grows in importance and individuals move up the corporate ladder (Brownell, 1993; Covey, 1977).

Brownell (2013) describes the skill set of effective listening with the HURIER model (Hearing, Understanding, Remembering, Interpreting, Evaluating, Responding). While the last two categories are well covered by most argumentation or debate textbooks, debaters and judges could benefit from studying the first four. While debater-judge communication during the round often approximates a linear sender-receiver model, Brownell's model is relational. In the "joint venture interaction" which constructs and negotiates meaning (Howell, 1982), listeners play a central role (Eisenberg & Goodall, 1993; Wolff & Marsnik, 1992). Brownell (2013) counsels that we can never "completely duplicate" the experience of whoever we listen to, but can only "approximate" by becoming a "good guesser" (p.41). In a debate context, a judge whose decision appears to approximately account for the intended meaning of most utterances in an excellent judge indeed!

Several factors influence the effectiveness of listening. Witkin and Trochim (1997) surveyed speech professionals to rate 98 distinct listening concepts and map them into clusters, and found that concepts in the active listening cluster achieved the highest average ratings among the 15 clusters. Their active listening cluster included affective processes, alertness, appreciation, conclusions, echoic memory, effort, motivation, purposeful activity, responding, sustaining, and voluntary concepts. Other researchers have argued that active listening requires impressive cognitive ability (Bostrom, 2011; Nichols, 1948), perceptual readiness (Brownell, 2013), attentive nonverbal posture (Brownell, 2013), concentration (Wolff & Marsnik, 1992),

manageable levels of anxiety (Whetten & Cameron, 1991), appropriate mental schemas (Edwards & McDonald, 1993), efficient inner speech (Johnson, 1993), and note taking (Bostrom & Searle, 1990). While note-taking is generally positive, it can be negative in some contexts (Waldhart & Bostrom, 1981) and non-verbal posture may account for many of its benefits (O’Heren & Arnold, 1991). The yearly insistence by the NDT Director that all judges get a good night sleep is excellent advice, and even the Healthy Debate Initiative might improve judging quality (Le Poncin, 1990). A debate round includes 432 different intervals (if measured as 10 second segments). Even under ideal conditions, most effective listeners will not sustain maximum listening effectiveness in each of these intervals.

Debate imposes unique challenges in the hearing stage of the listening process. Most in the NDT/CEDA community are familiar with the thought-speech differential – every day speech is often under 200 words per minute (wpm), while thought may exceed 500 wpm (Brownell, 2013). The gap between speech and thought enables time for productive listening practices such as mentally repeating (shadowing) a message, but this practice is quite difficult at speeds exceeding 150 wpm (Moray, 1969). Conversely, the thought-speech differential can also harm listening by enabling unrelated thoughts. Speech compression research (Beatty & Payne, 1984; Witkin, 1993) implies that debating might both increase one’s capacity for comprehension but can also increase the potential distraction when confronted with normal speed speech. While the reduced thought-speech differential in NDT/CEDA debate has positive cognitive effects, there are effects in both directions on listening.

Additionally, effective hearing requires discrimination, which means the ability “to isolate and identify sounds” (Brownell, 2013, p.76). Debaters

contribute to this problem by slurring words, missing syllables, low volume, lack of vocal variety, speaking into laptops, underdeveloped arguments, verbal filler, pronunciation ambiguities with unfamiliar names or words, and other clarity problems. These problems make it easy to hold debaters accountable for problems with hearing, but factors beyond an individual debater's control are also in play, including the clarity shortcomings of their opponent, secondary auditory stimuli which the judge is unable to ignore, disruptive inner speech on the part of the judge, etc.

There are additional challenges for debate judges in the understanding phase of listening. Listeners are engaged in a process of inner speech, but this internal dialogue is typically compressed to make it easier to process in relation to other concepts. A judge may hear 40 different words in between a tag line, citation, and evidence, but may process and write a very simplistic reference, such as "hurts political capital." This inner speech is semantically embedded in prior experience (Johnson, 1993), including past discussions, so a judge should be able to accurately process material they are familiar with. This familiarity could stem from research, coaching against an argument, judging other debaters on similar topics, or judging the same debater previously. Many observers of mutual preference judging suggest that a judge's debate ideology is important, and semantic embedding is among the reasons. Similarly, the concept highlights the benefit of knowing how a judge speaks or thinks about a concept, even if we assume judge objectivity is more than aspirational. Even if absolute objectivity is impossible, the aspiration is vital to effective judging and debating. The inability to suspend judgment impedes understanding a message (Kelly, 1982) and invites selective attention, card stacking, and disruptive inner speech (Brownell, 2013).

Problems with understanding in debate judging also disrupt hearing by creating anxiety. According to Brownell (2013), "Listening may deteriorate during the communication event as you realize that the material is difficult or confusing. Information that is difficult to process tends to accumulate as 'cognitive backlog' and subsequently creates additional anxiety and mental blocking" (p. 81). Inevitably, some concepts or referents will not be completely understood due to highlighting or the lack of judge familiarity. Various barriers to hearing may lead to missed words, compounding the effect as mental attention focuses on reconstructing missed words through context. Ideally, a judge can accept minor defects in understanding to prepare for the next utterance, but if the uncertainty compounds, the cognitive backlog will begin to disrupt inner speech. A successful judging experience requires both understanding critical concepts and avoiding excess anxiety, but cognitive backlog is disrupting to this constant balancing effort. In a conversational context, cognitive backlog could be handled via perception checking, which "is a specific response that (1) provides information to your partner regarding your understanding of what she said and then (2) allows your partner to modify or further clarify her original intent" (Brownell, 2013, p. 112). Since perception checking generally involves asking questions, the mechanism is delayed for an opponent and inaccessible for a judge.

The remembering phase of the listening process presents several additional challenges for debate judges. Although most debate judges consider note taking necessary, the real "flow" isn't just on paper, but in the judge's head. The notes themselves are both a way to understand (during the debate) and re-access the memory (after the debate). Since long term memory (LTM) processes involve delays exceeding 60 seconds

(Bostrom & Waldhart, 1980; Brownell, 2013), debate judging relies heavily on both immediate and short term memory (STM). Due to limitations in note taking, some judges even re-listen to segments of a debate (particularly the last rebuttals) after they've mostly completed their decisions.

Problems with remembering and understanding can also intersect. People listen using schemas, which are patterns of organization to help us perceive, filter, and recall information (Edwards & McDonald, 1993; Fitch-Hauser, 1990; Paris & Upton, 1976). For example, judges will look for the counter-interpretation in the topicality front-line, the alternative in a kritik shell, and the link in a disadvantage even if the debaters did not use those precise terms. Although one could deride such practices as interventionist or reconstructive, they are common and perhaps inevitable (as all judges use schemas, even if they are different). Schemas, however, are constantly evolving as we learn. They influence future expectations and future perceptions, so the use of different schemas can easily become a barrier to understanding and memory.

Perhaps the weakest phase of the debate judge's listening process is what Brownell (2013) refers to as interpreting. In normal conversation, listeners need to be empathetic, attentive to verbal and nonverbal cues, and aware of their interactions with each other. In debate, many judges focus their attention on their note-taking. This mode of listening may increase the chasm of misperception between performative and traditional approaches to debate, but in many debates it may be more important to focus on hearing, understanding, and remembering.

One might conclude that debate judging is an extremely difficult process, from a listening perspective.

Many highly successful debaters find it difficult to transition to judging, while others may have an aptitude for judging which exceeded their aptitude for debating. However, each of the listening difficulties identified above has been located in research outside of a debate setting. Brownell (2013) claims that “understanding is relative at best... meanings we assign are approximate” (p. 107) – this uncertainty is accelerated when a debate traverses a litany of global social problems under time compression. Given this, the fact that several debate rounds end with a judge and both teams in substantial agreement about what precise arguments were made and how they interacted, it may be that such post-round convergence of perspective is remarkable – and beautiful – thing! Even in situations where debaters disagree with a decision, they often agree with large parts of it. This paper will demonstrate how pre-speech file sharing, when properly deployed, can enhance the likelihood of a satisfactory post-round discussion.

Benefits of pre-speech file sharing

One important benefit of pre-speech file sharing with judges is improvement in the listening process – particularly the understanding and remembering phases. There are secondary benefits for debate efficiency, including the potential for feedback prior to the end of a debate and increasing decision and discussion time during the post round period. Further, pre-speech file sharing can serve as a check against two unscrupulous practices – clipping and disorderly speech document conduct.

Research on listening processes suggests there are several deficiencies in listening processes under the traditional model, where judge access to evidence is delayed until the post-round period. This delay is significant – nearly 45 minutes after the final cross

examination, and nearly 90 minutes after the 1AC was read. A wide range of factors beyond debater clarity can impede the quality of initial hearing. The reduced thought-speech differential undermines common techniques such as shadowing. Debaters cannot always anticipate when judges may rely more on inner speech, which can disrupt hearing. In some cases, cognitive backlogs compound, and the resulting stress impedes hearing. In other cases, application of schema to avoid cognitive backlogs may structure understanding in ways not always anticipated by the speaker. These factors can impede even when a judge is an ideal active listener, and are magnified if a judge is outside of their normal working hours, disinterested in round content, low on sleep, stressed, distracted, hungry, or thirsty.

Presumptively, most judges who request such documents do view them during speeches. Even if not, their availability can disrupt the anxiety effects of cognitive backlog. During a speech, cross-examination, or prep time, they provide an alternative means for perception checking to offset occasional hearing problems, whether caused by the debater, judge, or both. This can be important, since cognitive backlog related to one argument can impact the understanding of other arguments (just as link and uniqueness have mutual interactions). Increasing judge certainty about previously unfamiliar concepts, such as a term of art within the evidence, can enable the construction of new and more appropriate schemas to filter additional information. Visual cues are more important for some learning styles than others (Emmert, Emmert, & Brandt, 1993), but can overcome the limitations of immediate and short term memory in processing opponent refutations of evidence content and terminology. Flowsheets also function as visual cues, but often represent tags selected by the debater reading the evidence instead of terminology re-

appropriated through refutation. Further, an imperfect flowsheet corrected by speech document during the next prep time from a speech document is a more useful memory device for future speeches than one corrected after the debate ends.

Cross examination provides a particularly salient argument for visual access by judges. Many questions are grounded in evidence just recently read, and clarity shortcomings should not protect a debater from probing cross-examination questions. Furthermore, many questions focus word selection from evidence, and flowsheets are not transcripts. Even a speech transcript would not prepare a judge to process questions about portions of evidence which were not highlighted or read. While a post-round reading of the card might remind the judge of the cross-examination question about it, it is more likely that waiting an hour will disrupt memory of the exchange. It may be possible to use cross-examination tactics to bring a judge into the loop about the evidence in question, but such tactics rely on good-faith truth seeking from all parties, and may be inefficient uses of limited time. Widespread judge access to speech documents has the potential to enable far greater argumentative depth in cross examination questions than would be possible otherwise.

Even parts of evidence not unpacked in cross-examination can be more meaningfully explored in later speeches when the visual cue draws attention to terminology. Just as strategies grounded in advance knowledge of evidence are stronger, re-reading evidence with contested meaning or growing importance prior to the final rebuttals can enable more meaningful processing as the speech is given. Listening involves auditory association, which “is a matter of finding the specific category into which the incoming information fits so that it ‘makes sense’” (Brownell, 2013, p. 76).

If judges have pre-speech access to the same speech text information as debaters, the chances for correct association, particularly in the late rebuttals, are improved.

This improvement in understanding has the potential to improve the efficiency of debate rounds through at least two mechanisms. First, improving judge understanding of argument during the round would enable better judge feedback. Some judges are stoic, trying not to accidentally influence debaters through nonverbal leakage. That stoicism may be a barrier to resolving basic disagreements about reality, such as which card was read or skipped, or a cross-examination disagreement about what a card really means. If the judge can signal with confidence their read of the situation, it may minimize such derailments. Stoicism is beneficial when an issue is “live,” but signaling when an issue has been resolved enables debaters to move on with confidence. Second, judge access to speech documents can increase the efficiency of preparing for a post-round discussion which includes reference to particular texts from evidence. Long decisions disrupt tournament schedules, and many tournaments impose a hard cap on the amount of time available for post-round decisions which creates trade-offs between decision time and RFD (reason for decision) discussion. Having the files in advance can save 5-10 minutes of valuable decision time, and reviewing evidence during prep time could save as much as 20 minutes. Instead of reconstructing a decision to account for newly read evidence, judges can have the original construction account for a close reading of evidence. The benefits may be better reasoned decisions, more detailed RFD discussions, or simply more time for decompression before the next debate.

Finally, pre-speech access to documents has the potential to deter unscrupulous practices by making

them easier to detect. There are significant concerns about “clipping,” the practice of reading less than the highlighted portions of evidence, but misrepresenting the amount read to the judge in hopes that the judge will provide more credit than appropriate for the sections not actually read. Debaters caught clipping are likely to receive a loss with zero speaker points, and may face further action from their home institutions. However, it is difficult to act on suspicions of clipping without evidence to corroborate the accusation. Many judges who have decided clipping challenges felt comfortable doing so only after comparing the highlighting of a card to an actual recording of the debater. Access to the speech document allows judges to follow the speaker and immediately notice discrepancies between the highlighted portions and what is read in the debate. Some judges may even use pre-round speech documents actively mark cards as the round progresses.

Although not currently treated as an ethical violation, debaters express concerns about poorly constructed or misused speech documents, which impair the opposing teams’ access to information during the opponents’ speech. Three specific problems include (a) moving in a nonlinear fashion through the speech document, making it difficult for an opponent to follow along (b) putting additional evidence in a document as a distraction or (c) excessively withholding cards from the initial speech document. Pre-speech judge access to documents cannot eliminate these problems, but making judges aware is a necessary first step to building community norms against the practice. Since orderliness and accuracy have credibility effects (Brembeck & Howell, 1976), judges are likely to act once they become aware.

Drawbacks to pre-speech file sharing

Some judges decline when offered pre-speech access

to documents, and even criticize the practice on various grounds. The most common objections are (a) distraction of judges with information overload (b) incentivizing debaters to further sacrifice clarity for speed, (c) incentivizing evidence over analysis, (d) round delay related to file transfer time, and (e) encouraging harmful judging practices. There is merit (of varying degrees) in each of these objections, but the drawbacks can be minimized by conscious decisions by judges about how the documents are used.

Distraction effects can occur for many reasons beyond pre-speech document access, but they are quite real. There is growing awareness about how computer-mediated communication (CMC) encourages a destructive form of multi-tasking which undermines effective listening or cognitive processing. Paperless debate is a subset of CMC, and while learning styles vary, its practitioners should take this research seriously. Disruptive technology effects (Tellis, 2006) can harm listening through the stress of information overload. "When you attend to an auditory or visual cue, as when you surf the Web during class, it is drawn out from the background and becomes vivid. Other sounds and sights—like the lecture—are then perceived more dimly and remain in what listening researchers call the margin. There is always a tradeoff between depth and breadth of information processing" (Brownell, 2013, p. 78). Attempting to read along with each word might create challenges similar to shadowing at high rates of speed, and certainly a computer screen can remove one's eyes and perhaps hands from the task of note-taking. Parts of evidence not highlighted may also prove distracting, and exploring such derailments could re-create the cognitive backlog that judges seek to avoid. Awareness of one's own listening process is necessary, but can also be a distraction.

Hembrooke and Gay (2003) noted laptop use in classrooms is a form of multi-tasking which disrupts comprehension by distraction. Rockmore (2014) suggested screen processing ties into the “compulsion loop,” which is associated with addictive behavior and disrupts the learning process. Kraushaar & Novak (2010) found multitasking disrupted listening 42% of the time. Even when multi-tasking is controlled, Mueller & Oppenheimer (2014) suggest laptop note-taking weakens processing of complex concepts as students seek to transcribe a lecture instead of reframing it for shorthand. Effective flowsheeting also requires processing and selection, although transcription is also useful since turning points from the middle of the debate are easier to locate after the final rebuttals. At the risk of distraction, however, access to cards during the speech lowers the premium on card transcription, allowing judges more processing space during flowing. Given the likelihood that technology will continue to influence processing during and after rounds, it makes sense to understand its benefits and disruptions in search of a listening style which maximizes the former relative to the latter.

At the same time, some of the effects of CMC may be appropriate in the debate setting. The impersonal nature of CMC “may enhance the task-oriented functions of equalizing participation, coordination, and forth” (Brownell, 2013, p.320). Further, by replacing nonverbal cues with word choice cues (Olaniran, 1994), it may reinforce the sentiment of many that derived credibility (language use and warrants for arguments) should be prioritized above initial credibility (the pre-round reputation of debaters). Perhaps more important, judges experience negative CMC effects from having a laptop or tablet open, regardless of purpose, and could defer use of speech documents until cross-examination or prep time if they find them too distracting during the initial speech.

If the use of speech documents by judges encourages excessive speed and magnifies clarity problem, it would undercut the very purpose for requesting access. However, a conversation about enabling definitely needs to account for all of the shortcomings in current listening practice, as detailed above. Further, it should be recalled that the opponent, and not merely the speaker, is penalized when clarity problems interfere with judge processing. Judges are rarely willing to dismiss entire sections of speech on clarity grounds, and a judge bold enough to do so would probably not be deterred by having prior access to the speech document.

Used properly, speech documents may dissuade clarity problems by allowing a more precise remedies by identifying the unclear segments. First, speech documents create an immediate check on clipping, and clipping is closely related to clarity issues. Second, clarity problems may be greater in some areas than others, and judges can be more precise. Third, this precision could allow a judge to impose more precise penalties, such as overlooking a specific segment of text, instead of struggling to complete the enthymeme for the debater and giving undue credit. Whether a judge uses speech documents in a manner which results in a net increase or decrease in clarity depends more on the practice of the judge than access to the documents.

Another perspective on the speed/clarity tension would be to note that many of the listening problems detailed above could be minimized if debaters were slower and clearer. This is a fair reaction, particularly in the instance of clarity, but enforcement is a challenge. If rounds were 20% slower, this would presumably minimize content by 20%. In addition to the processing and understanding benefits of speech compression, rounds would need to be 25% longer to maintain the same depth. There is also considerable historical

evidence that judges cannot easily counter-act the obvious competitive incentive for speed unless they stop demanding debaters provide detailed refutation to each argument. Ultimately, it may be that effective remedies would be worse than the underlying problem, or at least more arbitrary. Certainly, judge confusion is not the ideal remedy.

The process of examining evidence after rounds undoubtedly prioritizes evidence relative to analysis. Reading more of the evidence prior to the final rebuttals might be viewed as a pre-construction alternative to post-round re-construction, and may make analytic arguments grounded in opponent evidence more meaningful. Of all the objections, this is the weakest – the problem existed long before paperless debating, and earlier evidence processing is better unless a judge is willing to operate only on their memory of evidence. Operating on memory risks substantial processing errors, as detailed above.

Many judges have decried the additional delays related to pre-round speech sharing, and adding an additional recipient could increase those delays. This effect should be minimal - most delays happen prior to successfully handing a drive to the opponent, not after. Using an email chain is often more efficient than flash drives, and the net delay of adding a judge to the chain is nearly zero. Copying data from the preview window instead of opening the file would also minimize this effect. With access to the file, the judge is better positioned to see and thus deter any actively unscrupulous file sharing practices which might increase the delay. Finally, the post round file sharing can add 5-10 minutes to the time needed to make a decision. For this reason, some judges request the documents even if they don't expect to inspect them during speeches.

The objection that a judge might use speech documents to rationalize inattentiveness during evidence reading is certainly plausible. It is also plausible that such a judge might be better able to hide a poor quality listening behind their reading of evidence. But, these are possibilities with post-round evidence reading as well, and even judges who rarely read evidence can give poor decisions. It's not reasonable, however, to assume this is the hidden agenda of most judges who request documents, particularly when those judges also flow closely, attend to cross-examination, and spend time between speeches preparing to listen effectively to the next speaker. This objection relates primarily to the motivations, not the techniques, of judges. In the hopefully rare event that a judge isn't motivated to judge well, making a decision appear less credible to debaters is hardly a satisfying remedy.

The full-information model of judging

Ultimately, this article argues that more information can improve the quality of debate judging. Although motivated by a narrow question (whether speech documents should be viewed before or after the round is complete), the importance and shortcomings of listening should be a concern for the debate community in a range of contexts. Judges who are motivated to increase their access to information for judging might go beyond pre-speech document access to record audio from rounds they judge, mark cards to deter clipping, manage disputes over meaning as they are happening, and flow cross examination. Each of these practices has the potential to distract judges, but each also has the potential to enable judges to minimize the effects of the many barriers to listening detailed above.

In the particular instance of pre-speech document access by judges, there are several barriers to effective

listening beyond debater clarity. These include opponent clarity, judge inner speech, cognitive backlog, short term memory limitations, and ineffective schemas. The linear and quick delivery in NDT/CEDA debate benefits listening skills by speech compression, but disrupts some listening adaptations such as shadowing and perception checking. Pre-speech access can thus improve listening quality through visual cues, while also improving round efficiency and deterring unscrupulous practices. Possible drawbacks to this method include judge distraction and incentives for sacrificing clarity to speed, analysis to evidence, and judging to laziness. Each of these drawbacks can be minimized, if not completely eliminated, by judges constantly monitoring their own listening habits and making adjustments. For example, a judge who finds they continually get distracted by the non-underlined words in cards might either use the *Verbatim* feature to show only the highlighted portions, or restrict their viewing of material between tag-lines to occasional spot-checks for clipping. Although it is possible for the drawbacks to outweigh the benefits for a particular judge, the reverse is likely with practice and experimentation.

Individual debate teams spend thousands of dollars traveling to distant tournaments to maximize their access to stronger competition and high-quality judging. Quality judging is a difficult and highly valued task. This approach to judging is admittedly more time- and energy-intensive than traditional judging practices, but the energy is worth expending in order to generate a higher quality decision and post-round explanation.

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